

Research Question: Through what mechanisms does the transition from income generation to asset ownership shape wealth accumulation in India?

The Great Indian Promise

Education, Ownership and The Future of Wealth Creation in Modern India

1.1) Background & Introduction: The Great Indian Promise

Imagine a child born in India in 2005. The parents are striving to save every single rupee that they can. The child attends a private school, spends multiple years in coaching classes, completing an engineering degree; finally landing a corporate job with a salary that comfortably exceeds anything their parents earn. From a conventional measure, the child is the success story of modern India.

However, by thirty, something does not add up. Homeownership feels farfetched rather than imminent. Savings slowly accumulate and are rapidly absorbed by rent, EMIs, and the swiftly increasing cost of living; rendering financial freedom elusive.

Entering the latter half of the decade, India finds itself associated with two seemingly contrasting reputations. India is among the fastest-growing economies—a trajectory that is largely attributed to the 1991 trade liberalisation—as the real GDP (adjusting for inflation) grew by 7.8% in the first quarter of FY 2026-27 (MoSPI, 2026). Moreover, the country is the fourth largest economy in the world, with a nominal GDP at roughly \$4.15 trillion, along with a per capita income of \$2,813 in 2026 (IMF, 2026). In the long run this achievement is even more impressive.

Approximately 171 million people moved out of extreme poverty between 2011-12 and 2022-23 (World Bank, 2025). By traditional measures of economic development such as real GDP expansion, poverty reduction and improved living standards, India's journey over the last decades can be considered a success.

On the contrary, the same decade has produced quite the opposing headline. The World Inequality Lab's research has used over a century's worth of data that concludes that the top 1% constitutes 22.6% of national income and 40.1% of national wealth. These are the highest levels since 1922 for income and 1961 for wealth. India's top 1% income share exceeds that of countries such as South Africa, Brazil and the United States (Bharti et al., 2024). The authors from the Inequality Lab claim that the "Billionaire Raj" has a stronger wealth concentration than the colonial raj it replaced. Inequality levels fell sharply after independence until the early 1980s, then it slowly began rising with a sudden acceleration in income inequality in the early 2000s.

Moreover, India has constructed a largely successful social contract, in which education was the ladder, stable employment was the destination, and prosperity was the final reward. For a majority of Indians; specifically, the first generation entrants into higher education and the formal economy—the financial ladder worked. As income rose, consumption expanded and a broad middle class took its shape. As a result, human capital gradually became the country's most valued resource.

The promise was compelling in nature due to the economic circumstances in the country at that point of time: an expanding formal sector, a global economy that was hungry for skilled, English-speaking workers. To this day, it remains a route out of poverty for a large cohort of the Indian population.

1.2) Research Gap & Contribution

A public and academic debate on Indian inequality has focused largely on the measurement of the income disparity in the country. A society can increase the flow of income to many households, while concentrating wealth in the hands of a small minority of the country. The top 1% earners in India account for 22.6% of national income (Bharti et al., 2024) . Although income can improve short-term living standards, long-term economic security is dependent on accumulated wealth.

Although the current literature documents the rise of inequality, limited attention has been given to connecting this trend with the composition of Indian households' balance sheets. This paper examines the economic mechanisms that explain the divergence between income growth and wealth accumulation. Therefore, the study aims to propose an integrated analytical framework that links education, income, ownership and wealth accumulation.

1.3) Research Focus

1. Why has income growth in India not translated proportionally into wealth accumulation for most households?
2. Why does wealth remain far more concentrated than income at the top of the distribution, even as education and income opportunities have broadened?
3. Which structural and behavioural mechanisms explain this divergence for Indian households?

1.4) Objectives & Scope

The paper's main objectives include:

- To distinguish the difference between Income & Wealth in an Indian context
- To investigate the mechanisms that weaken the conversion of income to wealth including differences in education, economic properties of human capital, composition of household balance sheets.

The scope of the study centralises on the transition from income to wealth accumulation in Indian households with particular attention to the principal beneficiaries of the education to employment social contract. The analysis delves into the relationship between education, income and ownership, and wealth accumulation, rather than the causes of income inequality, poverty mitigation and the redistribution of income. Methodologically, the study follows an interpretive framework by drawing upon secondary data and existing literature to develop an analysis.

Although the analysis is conducted at a national level, the regional and demographic differences are recognised where relevant. The proposed framework aims to explain the underpinning mechanism behind wealth accumulation in India and to provide a foundation for future empirical studies.

2.1) Analytical Framework

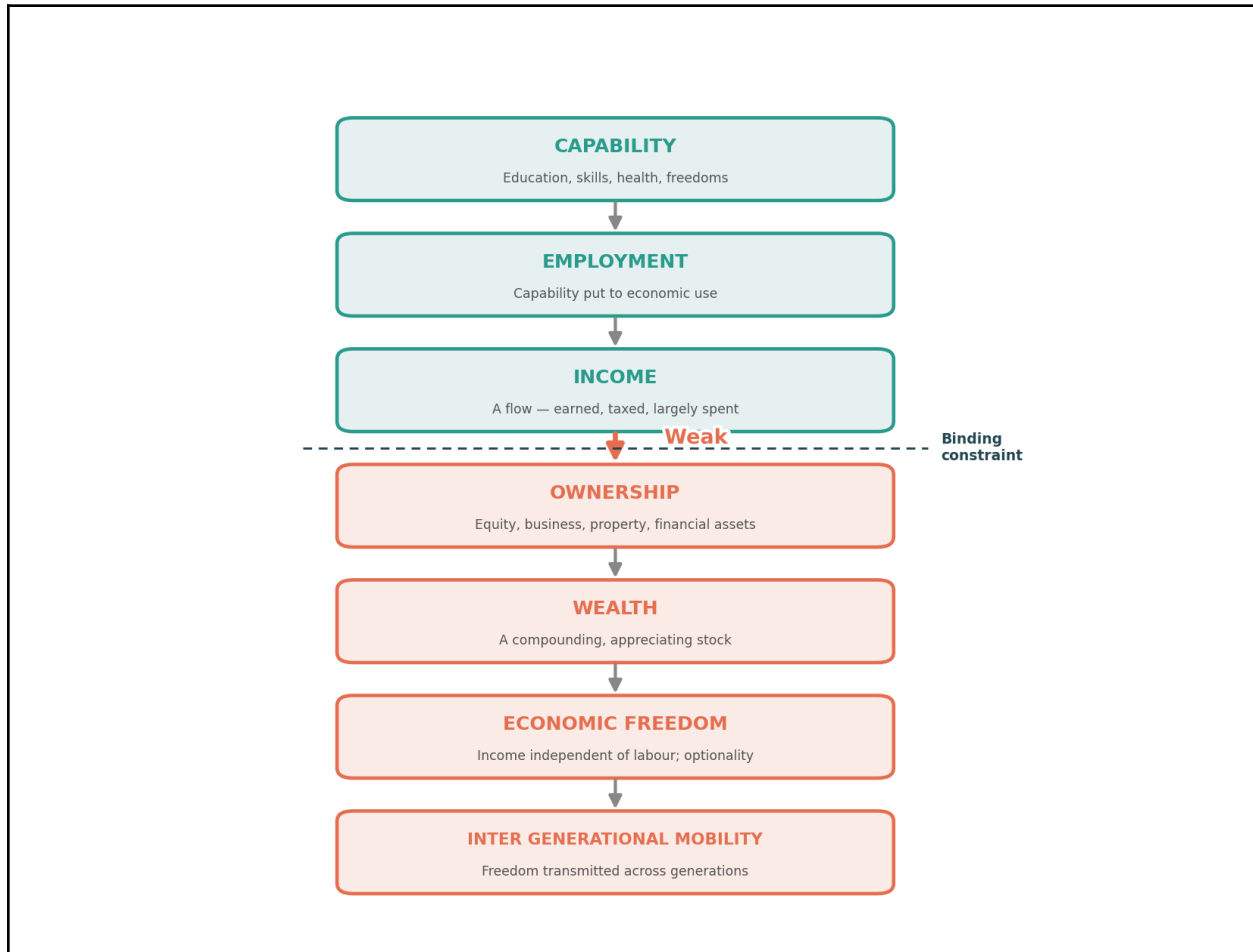


Figure 1 : Income & Wealth Framework

Income is a recurring flow of purchasing power received over time via salaries, profits, rent, interest, dividends, or government transfers; used to meet recurring expenses such as rent, school fees, EMIs, healthcare, and groceries. On the other hand, wealth represents the accumulated stock of assets minus the net liabilities held at any given point of time. Unlike income, wealth sustains, appreciates and creates access to potential future income streams and economic opportunities.

The difference between income and wealth helps explain why India's consumption data may suggest a relatively equitable country, whereas the wealth distribution statistics highlight a different story. Consumption statistics measure the flow of household expenditure at any given point of time—reflecting the current living standards. By contrast, wealth provides a more accurate picture of long term financial security and economic advantage. Since the 1991 economic liberalisation, Indian economic policy has centralised around accelerating economic growth, raising household income, and increasing consumption through financial inclusion schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), and welfare programmes including the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) and the National Food Security Act (NFSA). However, the policy emphasis that is examined in this paper focuses more heavily on income and financial inclusion rather than broad-based wealth accumulation.

This helps explain why a rising salary does not translate into wealth. If two individuals earn identical salaries and save the exact same portion of their income, the levels of wealth that they accumulate may vastly vary due to the concept of asset compounding. Compounding occurs when the yields of the assets are reinvested— which results in those returns generating greater returns, allowing wealth to have the snowball effect over time, as illustrated by Figure 2.

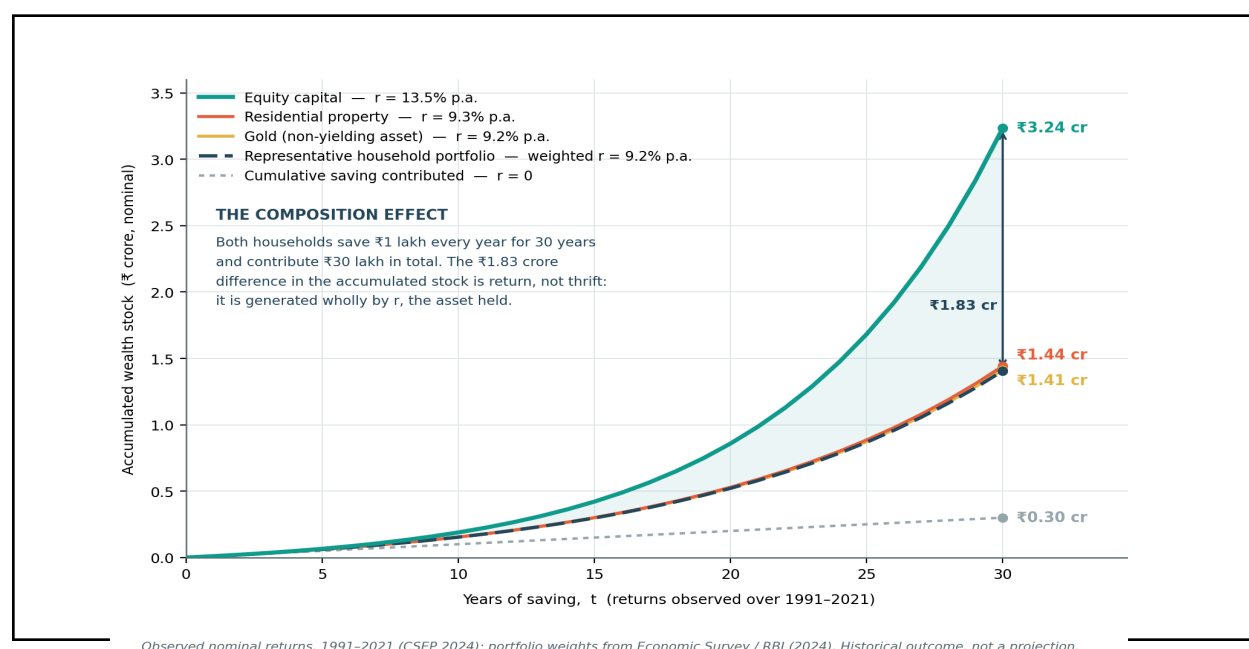


Figure 2: The Composition Effect: Why Identical Savers End Up Unequal.

Sources: Wahengbam (2023) – For Nominal Return on Asset

Figure 2 is derived using the future value of annuity, with the assumption that two separate households invest ₹1 lakh at the end of each year for 30 years. The final portfolio for each asset class is calculated by applying the observed annual nominal return (1991-2021) to the annuity formula, with both households contributing the principal of ₹30 lakhs. The households' portfolio return is calculated as weighted average of historical returns using the observed asset allocation of Indian household wealth reported by the Reserve Bank of India (2017), consisting of around 77% residential property, 11% gold and 5% financial assets, and the rest of the 7% in durable goods is excluded because these assets' values depreciate over time (RBI, 2017).

As a result, the portfolio is renormalised over the remaining 93% of wealth storing assets. The divergence between the returns for the Indian listed equity portfolio (₹3.24 crore) ; the gold; and the residential property portfolios (₹1.41–₹1.44 crore) is due to per annum compounding rate differences.

Therefore, a country can successfully raise the per capita income—as demonstrated by India with the per capita income rising from \$442 in 2000 to \$2,813— but, the ownership of productive assets may not increase proportionally (World Bank; IMF, 2026). Thus, wealth inequality is strongly shaped by the composition of assets rather than disposable income alone. Moreover, unless access to productive assets broadens, there will be a limited reduction in wealth inequality.

To compare how unequal income and wealth are, this paper uses a Gini index. It is a statistical measure of how far the distribution of wealth, income or consumption diverges from the line of equality (45 degree) among individuals or households. It ranges from zero to one, with zero denoting perfect equality and one denoting perfect inequality. A Lorenz curve graphs cumulative percentages of total income/wealth on the y axis against the cumulative percentage of population on the x axis as illustrated in Figure 3. The Gini index measures the area between the line of equality(the 45° diagonal) and the Lorenz curve (*PIB Backgrounder*, 2017).

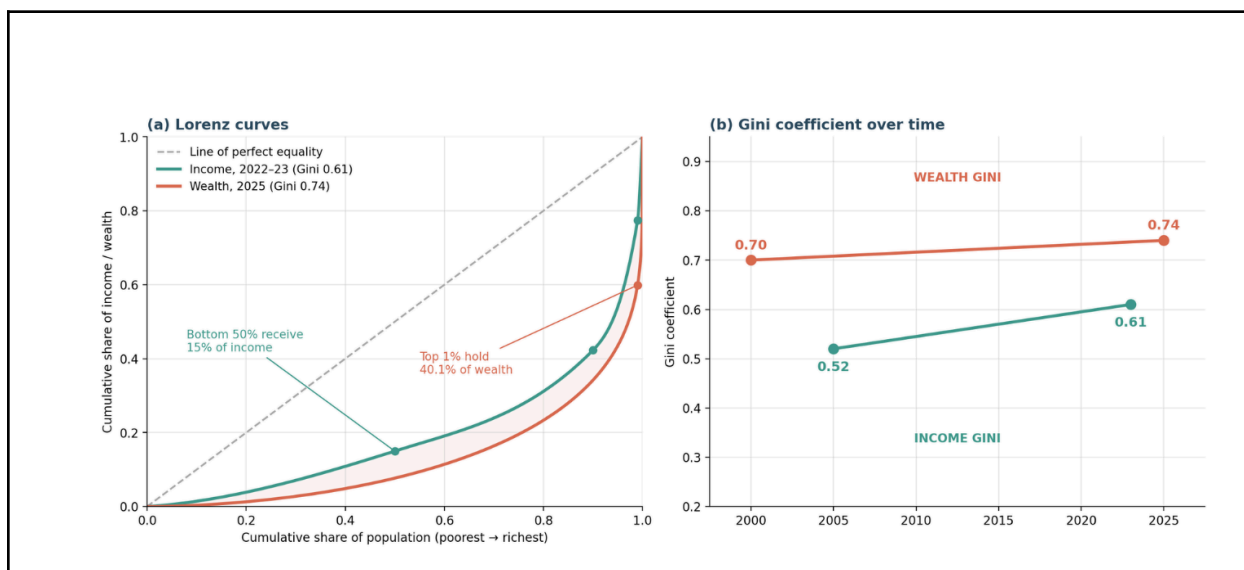


Figure 3: Gini Coefficient for Wealth and Income in India

Source: (UBS, 2024), (World Inequality Lab, 2024)

***Estimates are collated from various sources and levels are not strictly comparable**

India's Gini-Index yields contrasting outcomes based on the metric used: When consumption is used as the metric, the Gini-Index is estimated at 0.255 in 2022-23, falling from 0.288 in 2011-12. This makes India the fourth most equal country in terms of consumption distribution (World Bank, 2025). Whereas, when income is used as the metric, WID estimates that the Gini-Index rose from 0.52 in 2005 to 0.61 in 2023 (World Inequality Lab, 2024). On the other hand the wealth Gini-index is approximately 0.74 in 2024, rising from around 0.7 in 2000—making it one of the most unequal countries in terms of wealth accumulation (World Inequality Lab, 2024).

From Figure 3, there are two features that are central to the rest of the paper. The first is the changes in wealth and income: across the last two decades, the country's economic growth and its standard of living improved, while the opportunities to generate income and to accumulate wealth became more unequal—with wealth more concentrated at 0.74. Consumption reflects current living standards and income reflects the flow of earnings from employment, while wealth

is a result of savings, investments and inheritances. The second feature is the economic mechanism that is implied by the divergence.

Consumption inequality is truncated at both the higher and the lower end of the distribution. At the lower end, subsidies, welfare transfers, and rising household borrowing increase consumption levels beyond what their disposable incomes would otherwise allow. At the upper end, consumption is naturally limited: even for the wealthiest households in India, there is a finite limit to what they can consume. The capital that is not consumed accumulates, compounds over time and has no upper bound limit or ceiling. Consumption inequality fell over time; however, income and wealth inequality have risen. The consumption gini reflects the differences in current living standards, while the wealth gini reflects the cumulative result of saving, investment and inheritance. As a result, wealth inequality can be considered as a more holistic measure of a household's economic resilience, by determining its ability to withstand recessions and economic shocks, seize opportunities and pass these benefits on to the future generations

Moreover, it may be argued that consumption figures portray India as a relatively equal nation, whereas the wealth and income estimates appear to be the outlier. This interpretation is subject to two essential objections. Firstly, the consumption figures in India are partly sustained by government transfers and household borrowing. From March 2025 household debt has increased from 41.3% of the country's GDP to 45.5% by September 2025. Non-housing retail loans (credit cards, personal loans, durable finance) constituted 55.3% of household borrowing in September 2025 and increased to 58.4% by March 2026—with housing loans accounting for 26-29% (RBI, 2026b). The over-reliance on indebtedness can sustain consumption in the economy in the short run without augmenting household wealth. Debt-financed consumption can create a gap between living standards and the household balance sheet's strength. Even though it increases households' immediate purchasing power; a majority of non-housing borrowing creates an additional liability without corresponding assets. As a result, households with access to capital have a greater capacity to direct their savings and borrowing towards appreciating assets. However, low-income households face capital constraints to accumulate assets as the debt obligations and the rising costs absorb a majority of their financial resources. This further widens the divergence for wealth accumulation, creating further inequality.

Secondly, an objection of wealth inequality arises from its measurement resulting in an understatement of the true extent of inequality. Unlike consumption, wealth at the top of distribution cannot be directly identified through household surveys, which systematically undersample the wealthiest households. Consequently, the estimates of wealth inequality rely on modelling that combines survey data with national accounts. Therefore, correcting for the missing top tail would strengthen the conclusions of the magnitude of wealth inequality in India.

2.2) The Engine: Return Heterogeneity

The difference between income and wealth generation can be explained by three variables: the real return on capital (r), the real growth of the economy (g), and the real growth of wages. The real return on capital is the annual rate at which assets increase, after adjusting for inflation. Piketty (2014) argued that when r constantly exceeds g , wealth grows faster than the economy and this consolidates assets with the owners of capital allowing wealth inequality to persist.

India's nominal equity return of 13.5%, compared with a real GDP growth of 6-7%; this suggests that $r > g$ —however, the comparison uses a nominal value alongside real value creating inconsistencies. Expressed in real terms the nominal equity return is around 6-7% (Table 1), which is approximately equal to g . Thus, India's data does not indicate a general $r > g$; instead it shows return heterogeneity: the typical household portfolio earns below g , broad equity earns roughly g and ownership is concentrated among wealthier households who consistently earn above g .

This gap is even more evident at the household level. Wages are earned and spent, whereas assets such as property, businesses, and shares appreciate in value and generate returns that can be reinvested. Over time, this compounding can allow wealth to grow much faster than disposable income (income that is left over after paying taxes and mandatory deductions). Between 1991

and 2001, household salaries increased by around 9% in nominal terms, with experienced inflation approaching 8-11%, driven by augmenting education and living costs, leaving real wage growth at around zero. Therefore, a household whose income is rising, but whose savings earn less than g , will accumulate wealth slowly regardless of its income growth.

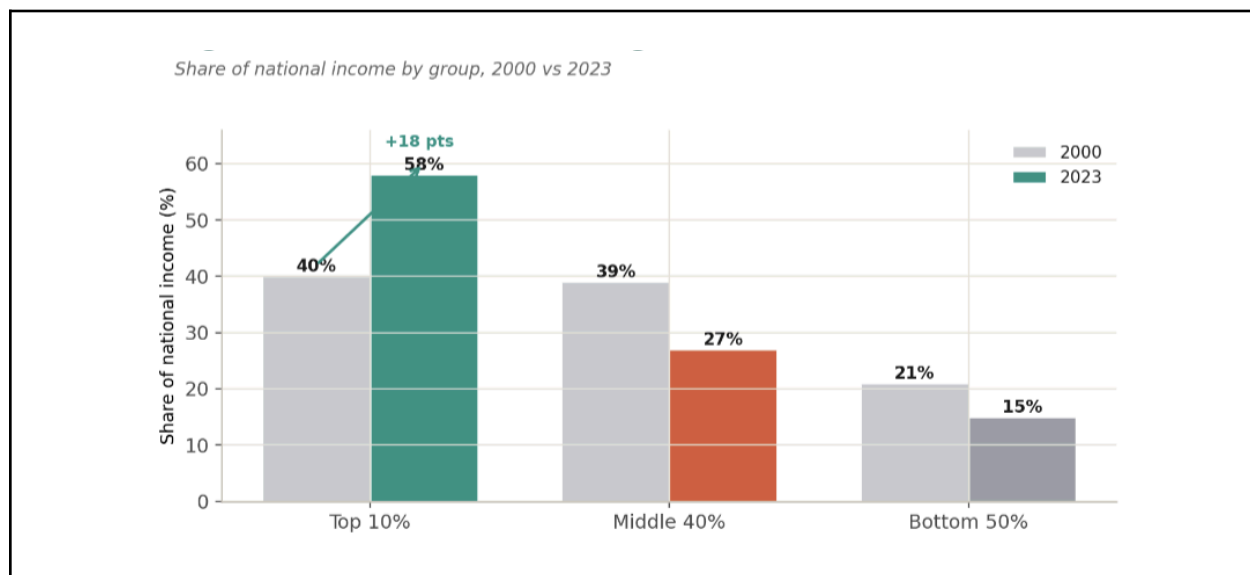


Figure 4: Income Distribution In India Between 2000 and 2023.

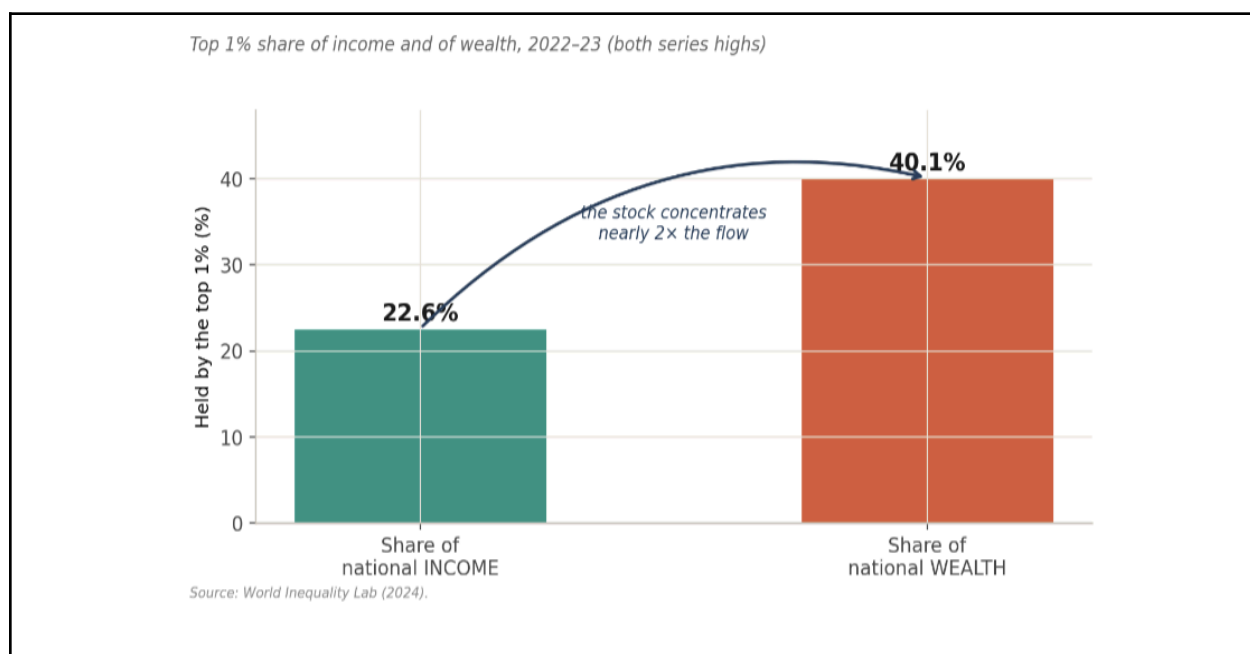


Figure 5: Share of National Income Vs Share of National Wealth

This is consistent with the distribution of income and wealth. Between 2000-2023, the top 10% share of national income grew from 40% to 58%, while the middle 40% share fell from 39% to approximately 27% (Figure 4). Moreover, in 2022-23, the top 1% held around 40.1% of national wealth, but only receives 22.6% of national income, the highest readings in the WID series (Figure 5). Furthermore, using Forbes rich lists, Bharti et al. (2024) report that the real net wealth of Indian billionaires grew by 280% between 2014 and 2022, which is around ten times the growth of national income in the country (27.8%). In 2024 India added 39,000 dollar-millionaires to reach a cumulative total of 917,000. Taken together, the evidence suggests that advantage at the top comes from concentrated stakes, early entry and inherited assets. This demonstrates how return heterogeneity is a mechanism through which wealth inequality may persist even as income opportunities broaden.

2.3) The Education Paradox

Human capital refers to the collective economic value of workers' knowledge, skills and health that raises an individual's productivity and therefore their earnings. It is a form of capital that is accumulated through the relinquishment of present consumption as expectations of the future returns. However, human capital is distinct from financial and physical capital in three different aspects. These differences drive the divergence between income and wealth accumulation. Education can augment the income earned by an individual, but human capital itself does not correspond to a stock of compounding wealth. As a result the expansion in human capital can increase earnings, without creating a direct transferable base of financial or physical wealth.

The first major difference is that human capital cannot be separated from its owner. Financial and physical capital can produce capital gains that are independent of the individual's labour; human capital generates greater economic returns primarily through individual participation in the labour market. A degree may increase a worker's marginal productivity and their overall employability. However, it does not generate income streams once the individual stops working. Consequently, the continuous investment in education increases the labour income rather than creating independent sources of capital gains. This limits the economic freedom of the individual, as they are reliant solely on their occupation to generate capital and sustain their lifestyle.

Secondly, human capital is non-transferable and weakly collateralizable. Distinct from financial and physical capital, it cannot be sold, easily pledged as collateral or transferred as an inheritance. Moreover, an individual's education cannot be utilised to directly secure a loan to finance investment. Banks do lend against expected income through an unsecured personal loan, but the credit is much costlier and smaller than lending against secured assets. This may create a major credit constraint for households. Furthermore, banks usually lend to individuals who have assets that can be seized and liquidated if they default on their loans. Thus, a household may possess high expected future income due to its substantial pool of human capital, but it does not directly translate into wealth. As a result, the household is credit-constrained in terms of its access to capital. Specifically, for low-income households, this increases the burden, as they lower their living standards and lifestyle in order to finance the basic requirements. However, in Indian households, there is a prevalent belief that a degree is a guaranteed pathway to success, and that expectation may reinforce a cycle where households prioritise investments in human capital without a corresponding increase in ownership in financial or physical capital.

Furthermore, Indian families spend an estimated 20–30% of their income on education, with aggregate household expenditure on education totaling a staggering ₹8.43 lakh crore (Kodak, 2026). Moreover, with education inflation averaging around 10–12%, the continuous expenditure on education spending may create competition for every seat at an institution; as every family increases spending on ranks, a good placement becomes subjective and entirely based on monetary incentives rather than ability (Kodak, 2026). Apart from that, there is an underlying issue with the education system in India: the curriculum is built around measurable academic credentials through a mountain of textbooks and a never-ending series of exams. Whereas essential life skills like financial literacy and capital allocation are often absent from formal education, these are necessary to build a financially capable nation. This creates a mismatch between employers and employees, as academic credentials do not always translate into the practical skills required by firms. While the education system is determined to evaluate a candidate's ability to perform in an examination-based environment, it does not develop their ability to evaluate risk, manage personal finances, and diversify assets.

Thirdly, human capital's value depreciates over time and it cannot be diversified. India's graduate unemployment of roughly 13% against an overall rate near 3.2% unemployment in 2023 is evidence of the limitation of the great Indian promise (MoSPI, PLFS 2022-23). Moreover, human capital cannot be liquidated when its expected return declines. When technological changes make certain skills obsolete, the individual bears the consequences of the change. As a result of that they have to invest to improve their skills to meet market requirements. This creates a significant opportunity cost, as the time and financial resources invested by households could have been invested in financial or physical capital to augment their wealth.

Moreover the taxation of labour income influences the transition from income to wealth. Under the new tax-regime for the AY 2026-27, any income above ₹24 Lakh is taxed at 30%. Even though the government has applied a progressive tax regime; for households dependent on labour income it would mean that wealth accumulation is shaped by the portion of income remaining after taxation and consumption. Thus, taxation creates an important distinction between the earning income and accumulating wealth: labour income is taxed as it is generated, while accumulated assets continue to appreciate over time.

Thus, education creates a trade-off between the earning capacity and accumulating capital that generates independent returns.

2.4) Asset Breakdown

Table 1: Indian Household Balance Sheet

Sources: Asset shares: RBI (2017), Returns: Wahengbam (2023)

Asset	Share of Household Assets (in %)	Nominal Return (1991-2021) in %	Type	Real Return Vs CPI Inflation (%)	Real Return - g

Real Estate	77	9.3	Appreciating	2~3% (before costs & taxes)	-3 to -5 pts
Gold	11	9.2	Appreciating	2~4%	-2 to -5 pts
Durable Goods	7	Negative	Consumption	Negative	More negative than g
Financial Assets (Deposits +Equity)	5	Deposits: 6-7%; Equity: 13.5%	Preserving/Compounding	Deposits ~0% or slightly negative (post-tax often negative) Equity: 6~7%	Deposits: -6 to -7 pts Equity: -1 to +1 pts

Table 1 highlights a major structural asymmetry in the composition of Indian household wealth: the assets that account for the bulk of the household balance sheet are not those that have the highest real returns. This composition matters because households' vast majority of assets lie in low-return assets. Over time, this reduces the capital available for investment which lowers the real return for households; slowing the growth rate of wealth in Indian households. Moreover, property is illiquid and non fungible; each individual property does not have identical characteristics such as size and location. This makes it difficult for households to shift their capital from one asset to the other.

Housing is the best example of this trade-off. Real estate accounts for 77% of all Indian households assets—the highest share among all asset classes. However, its nominal return of 9.3% does not translate into a high real return. The return on real estate falls to 2-3% after accounting for inflation. Furthermore, the purchase of a home does not yield a recurrent source of cash inflow for the household; even though it eliminates the need to pay rent. Thus, a major share of household wealth is constrained to assets that have limited scope for compounding in the long run.

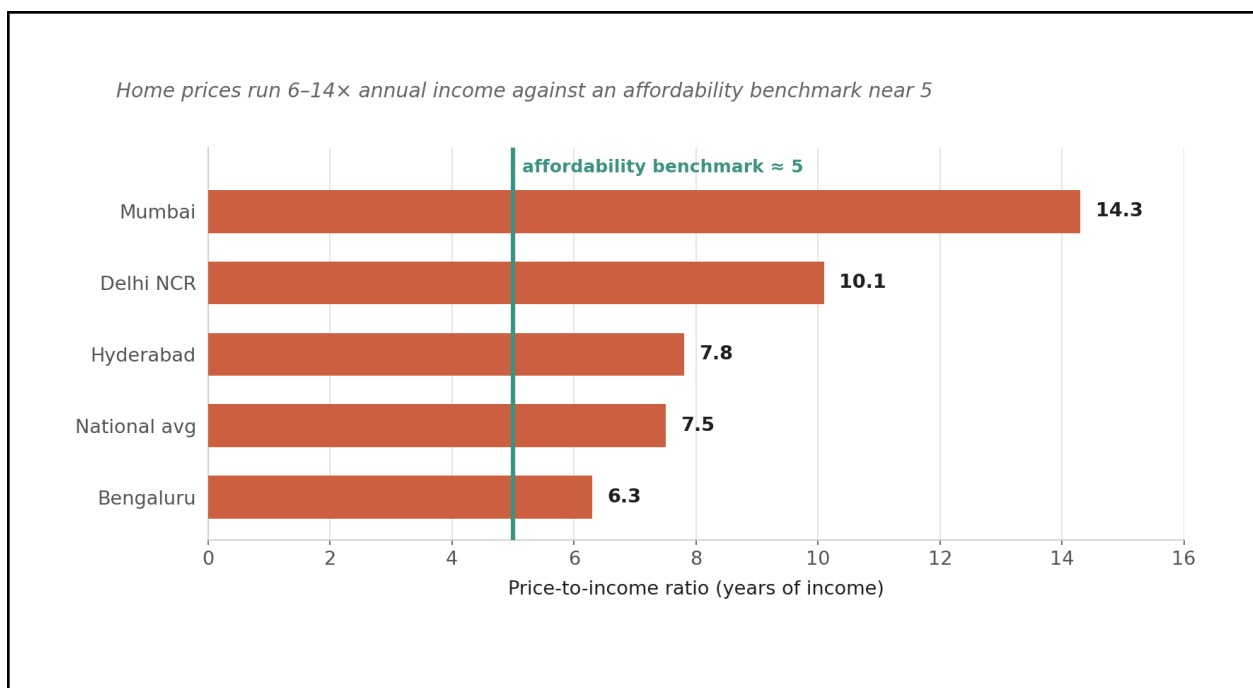


Figure 6: Price to Income Ratio For Indian Cities

Source: Pai (2024)

This constraint is further intensified through the growing costs of housing relative to household income. Figure 6 illustrates the national house price-to-income ratio average for India is at around 7.5. However, in metropolitan hubs like: Mumbai (14.3); Delhi-NCR (10.1); Hyderabad (7.8); Bengaluru (6.3). Households have to commit a greater portion of their earnings to purchase physical property. This reduces the disposable income that was previously available for diversifying assets. This increases the opportunity cost of households investing in real estate.

Thus, the problem with vast investments in real estate extends beyond the return on housing alone. Apart from entry timing, the rising costs of acquiring property further limit the ability of a household to allocate capital in other asset classes.

On the other hand gold has a similar issue, as it accounts for 11% household assets with a nominal return of 9.2%. Moreover, the return is driven primarily by the price appreciation which partly reflects the effects of domestic inflation rather than an increase in purchasing power of the asset. Moreover, the acquisition of gold erodes return immediately as the making charges of roughly 8–25% are lost at purchase and never recovered on resale. However, gold can still be utilised as a store of value and form of financial security during periods of economic uncertainty.

It functions as a rational and safe asset that is used as an insurance to preserve wealth when other assets and income sources are placed under pressure. Thus, the issue is not with the ownership of gold rather it is with the share of gold amongst all asset classes in an Indian household.

Equity is different from real estate and gold, as it can generate and reinvest income which allows wealth to compound over time. The overall participation in financial markets has drastically increased, with monthly SIP inflows surpassing ₹32,000 Crore (Association of Mutual Funds in India, 2025). Promoters held 50.1% of the market capitalisation of NSE-listed firms in September 2025 (NSE, 2025). Retail investors held around 9.1% and individual investors held around 18.7% (NSE, 2025). Even though these figures illustrate the shift towards the expansion of equity based assets, it does not necessarily mean that a large portion of household wealth has shifted towards these financial assets. Consequently this maintains the disparity in wealth accumulation as concentrated ownership ensures that households with greater capital can increase ownership and capture a greater portion of future capital gains.

Participation remains concentrated among high-income households. Lower-income households generally have limited financial knowledge; consequently, they are less familiar with equity based investment. They are more likely to focus on assets that are familiar and safer such as gold and bank deposits. As a result, even though the participation in financial markets increases, the underlying cause of the unequal distribution of financial wealth persists. Furthermore, another

issue with the market is the entry timing. Households that purchased property or equities before the economic booms of the 2000s and 2010s benefited from appreciating prices. However, later entrants have higher prices relative to their income. Moreover, wealth passes across generations in a manner that income does not. India has no inheritance tax: the estate duty was abolished in 1985. As a result, the subsequent generations receive their assets untaxed. This further weakens intergenerational mobility as individuals who are born into wealthy households start with an asset portfolio that others need to work their entire life to accumulate. As a result, family wealth does not only influence the income an individual earns but it influences their capacity to accumulate wealth themselves.

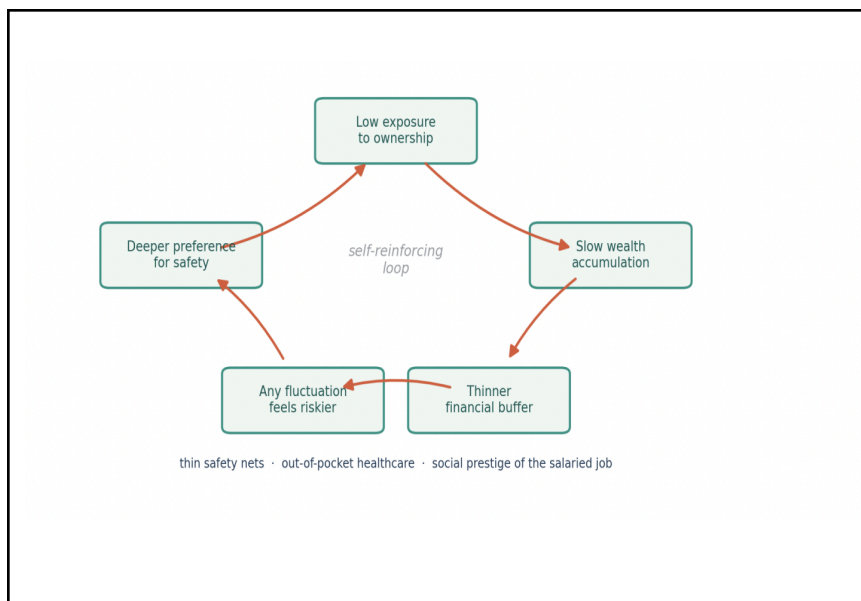


Figure 7: Security Trap

This may create a security trap: households with limited financial buffers have a lower capacity to cushion the losses from fluctuations in financial markets, establishing equity-based assets as risky. This preference can be explained through the mechanism of loss aversion, where the potential losses are perceived to be higher than the perceived gains (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979). As a result, they remain concentrated in safer assets which limits their exposure to compounding assets. This results in a self-reinforcing cycle that limits the ownership of compounding assets. This cycle is further reinforced by high out-of-pocket health-care costs (39.4% of total health expenditure in 2021-22), thin social safety nets and the importance of a

stable job (NHSRC, 2024) . This increases the cost of financial loss which makes the predilection to opt for safer assets more understandable.

Section 3 – Limitations

This paper has three main limitations. Firstly, the paper is reliant on secondary, national-level data, rather than household level data. This would allow the proposed mechanisms to be tested by each income group. Secondly Figure 2 depicts a hypothetical scenario where two households save an identical amount with different assets. This is done to illustrate the mechanism of compounding. Thirdly, the evidence presented in this paper establishes association rather than causation. The mechanisms explained in sections 2.2-2.4 are documented and explained individually, but the paper does not have a method to independently test which combination of mechanisms contributes most to the divergence between income and wealth.

Section 4 - Conclusion

The paper started with a child and a promise: that education would eventually lead to employment, employment to income, and in time prosperity through wealth. Figure 1 illustrates the Great Indian Promise as a ladder that moves from capability through employment and income to ownership, wealth, economic freedom, and ultimately intergenerational mobility. This analysis suggests that an important constraint lies not in generating income, but in the ability to translate that income to the ownership of productive assets and subsequently accumulated wealth.

The difference between income and wealth is central to this argument. Income represents the purchasing power that can improve current living standards. On the other hand, wealth represents the accumulated stock of assets that can generate future income, provide economic security, and promote intergenerational mobility. This divergence helps explain why an increase in income does not necessarily translate into a proportional increase in wealth. The frameworks examined in this paper help explain the central reasons for this divergence: the average portfolio has a real rate below the real growth rate of the economy; education can increase income without directly increasing accumulated wealth; and household wealth remains concentrated in property and gold.

However, as section 3 notes these mechanisms cannot be tested independently and cannot establish a causal relationship.

Ultimately, the significance of The Great Indian Promise lies in the difference between earning and owning. The transition from income to wealth is neither automatic nor uniform: households across the country with an identical income may follow two vastly different wealth trajectories. Consequently, this paper interprets the promise not as a failed promise, but as an incomplete one. If the barrier between income and ownership can be overcome, the promise can transition from income generation to sustained wealth accumulation and intergenerational mobility.

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